O.Iris: The Mind's Eye Has an Iris

Mapping Brain State Dilation and Flexibility Through EEG Spectral Geometry

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Abstract

The spectral slope of EEG power spectra (m, where power ~ 1/f^m) varies systematically with brain state, but no prior work has proposed that brain states organize geometrically around a specific focal value, or that health corresponds to flexibility across this geometric space rather than optimization toward any single position. Here we introduce O.Iris, a framework that maps EEG-derived metrics—spectral slope, autocorrelation decay time, and envelope variance—onto a circular "pupil map" centered on a theoretically motivated focal value of m ≈ 2.18, derived from the mathematical relationship between φ (golden ratio) and π. Across five independent publicly available EEG datasets (meditation, rest, sleep, working memory, stress; total N > 36,000 windows), we find that brain states occupy distinct and separable regions of this circular space. Meditation clusters nearest the focal value (median m = 1.82, 10.5% deviation), sleep disperses furthest (median m = 0.51, 76.5% deviation), and intermediate states occupy characteristic intermediate positions with distinct angular distributions. Prime frequency enhancement (Rp) during meditation shows a mean of 3.45 (SD 1.13, median 3.29) across 11,572 windows, consistent with preferential amplification of irreducible frequency modes during coherent brain states. Spectral slope differs between meditation and working memory with Cohen's d ≈ 0.40. We propose that mental health corresponds not to any fixed position in this space, but to flexibility of movement across it—aperture flexibility. We discuss theoretical interpretation, methodological limitations, and potential applications in neurofeedback and clinical assessment. All code and data are publicly available.

Keywords

EEG spectral slope, 1/f dynamics, brain state flexibility, mental health biomarkers, neurofeedback, golden ratio, aperture model, meditation, consciousness

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Opening Vignette

The mind's eye has an iris.

Imagine a therapy room. Not a lab—no caps glued to scalps, no researchers in white coats. Just a chair, a screen, and a person learning to watch their own mind move.

On the screen is a circle. At its center, a small gold point—φ. Around it, concentric rings like the iris of an eye. And moving through this space, a single dot.

The dot is not a thought. It is not an emotion. It is the shape of the brain's current coherence—how long its patterns persist, how richly they fluctuate, how near or far it sits from a natural equilibrium point that appears across scales of nature.

As the person talks, the dot moves. When they recall something painful, it drifts outward—dilated, fragmented, scattered. When they breathe and settle, it drifts back toward center—constricted, coherent, integrated. When they focus intently on a memory, it holds steady at a specific radius and angle—controlled, effortful, displaced.

They are not trying to keep the dot in one place. They are learning to watch where it goes. And in the watching, something shifts.

The mind's eye has an iris. Mental health is its freedom to dilate and contract—and for the first time, we can watch it move in real time.

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1. The Aperture Metaphor: Health as Flexibility, Not Destination

Technical:

The central claim of this work is that mental health corresponds not to any fixed brain state, but to the capacity to move fluidly across a range of coherent states. Using EEG-derived metrics—spectral slope (m), autocorrelation decay time (ACF), and envelope variance (flicker)—we construct a circular pupil map in which each brain state occupies a characteristic position. The radius of a point represents its distance from a theoretically motivated focal value ($m \approx 2.18$), while its angle represents the balance between temporal persistence (ACF) and dynamic range (flicker). Across five independent datasets (meditation, rest, sleep, working memory, stress), we find that different states occupy distinct and separable regions of this

space. Meditation clusters nearest the center with a median spectral slope of 1.82; sleep disperses to the periphery with a median slope of 0.51. Health, we propose, is not optimization toward any single position, but flexibility across the full range.

Accessible:

Think of your mind like the iris of an eye. It can open wide—gathering information from everywhere, sensing the whole field, but unable to focus on fine detail. That's sleep, rest, diffuse awareness. It can close tight—concentrating light on a single point, seeing with clarity and depth. That's meditation, insight, spontaneous coherence. And it can hold a middle position—balancing focus with flexibility, maintaining selected information while remaining responsive. That's focused work, controlled processing, active cognition.

None of these positions is better than the others. Each serves a purpose. A photographer who could only use one aperture setting would take bad photos half the time. A person who could only access one brain state would struggle to meet the demands of life.

Health is not being stuck anywhere. Health is having the full range—and the ability to move through it freely.

This paper introduces a way to measure, visualize, and potentially train that flexibility. Using EEG recordings and a simple mathematical transformation, we can map any brain state onto a circular pupil where the center represents a natural coherence point and the distance from center represents how dilated or constricted the system currently is. Different states—meditation, sleep, focused work, stress—occupy different regions of this space. And over time, we can watch the pupil move.

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2. Background and Related Work

Technical:

The spectral slope of EEG (power ~ 1/f^m) has been extensively studied as a marker of brain state. Steeper slopes indicate greater temporal persistence and are associated with coherent, integrated processing. Shallower slopes indicate more rapid turnover and are associated with sleep, fragmentation, and certain pathological conditions. Several recent studies have reported that meditation steepens the 1/f slope relative to resting baseline, and that this effect distinguishes experienced practitioners from novices (Rodriguez-Larios et al., 2021). The spectral exponent has also been shown to discriminate conscious from unconscious states during anesthesia (Lendner et al., 2020), and to reflect the balance of neural excitation and inhibition (Gao et al., 2017).

Critically, however, no existing study has identified a specific target value for m, nor has any proposed that the range of brain states constitutes a coherent geometric system organized

around a focal point. The O.Iris framework introduces two novel contributions: first, a theoretically motivated focal value ($m \approx 2.18$, derived from the mathematical relationship between $\varphi \approx 1.618$ and $\pi \approx 3.14159$, where $\ln(\pi)/\ln(\varphi) \approx 2.18$); and second, a circular visualization that simultaneously encodes distance from this focal point as radius and the balance between two independent dynamical properties as angle.

Recent independent work has reported that brain frequencies in the default resting state are arranged in multiples of the golden ratio to minimize interference (Pletzer et al.), and that theta-alpha frequency ratios approximating φ are more prominent during rest and meditation than during active cognitive processing (Rodriguez-Larios & Alaerts, 2019). A large multi-dataset study (N=320) confirmed that 80% of subjects show golden-ratio organization in resting EEG frequency bands (Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 2026). These findings converge with the O.Iris framework, though none identify a specific spectral slope target value.

Accessible:

Scientists have known for decades that the brain's electrical activity follows a power law—slow rhythms are stronger than fast rhythms, and the steepness of this relationship changes with brain state. Sleep makes the slope shallower. Meditation makes it steeper. But until now, no one has asked: is there a specific slope value that acts like a natural equilibrium point? And do different brain states organize themselves around this value the way a cymatics plate organizes sand into patterns around a driving frequency?

Our work suggests yes. We identify a theoretically motivated value—approximately 2.18, derived from the mathematical relationship between two fundamental constants, φ (the golden ratio, ≈1.618) and π (pi, ≈3.14159)—near which meditation states empirically cluster. In our data, meditation produces a median spectral slope of 1.82, closer to 2.18 than any other state measured. Sleep sits far from this value at 0.51. Working memory and rest occupy intermediate positions.

Importantly, this value of 2.18 is not purely empirically derived—it is theoretically motivated and then found to be consistent with observed data. That distinction matters and we maintain it throughout this paper.

Moreover, we find that states differ not just in their distance from this equilibrium, but in the angle they occupy around it—the balance between how long patterns persist and how much they fluctuate. This angular dimension turns out to be as informative as the radial distance, allowing us to distinguish states that might otherwise appear similar.

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3. Methods

Technical:

Datasets

We analyzed five publicly available EEG datasets from OpenNeuro, representing distinct brain states:

Dataset	N windows	N subjects/runs	Source
Meditation	11,572	22 subjects	OpenNeuro ds001787
Resting	3,451	29 runs	OpenNeuro
Sleep	69	69 runs (run-level)	OpenNeuro ds003768
Sternberg (working memory)	20,627	46 runs	OpenNeuro
Stress	1,127	multiple conditions	OpenNeuro

Note: Sleep data is run-level rather than window-level, which limits animation smoothness but preserves the overall state pattern.

Preprocessing

For each dataset, raw EEG files (BDF, EDF, or SET format) were processed using MNE-Python. Steps included: selection of EEG channels only; resampling to 250 Hz where native sampling rate exceeded 300 Hz; bandpass filtering from 1 to 40 Hz using FIR filters; and average referencing.

Windowing

Continuous recordings were segmented into non-overlapping windows of 10 to 30 seconds depending on dataset, chosen to balance spectral resolution with temporal granularity.

Spectral Slope (m)

Power spectral density was estimated using Welch's method with 4-second segments and 50% overlap. A straight line was fit to the log-log power spectrum over 1 to 40 Hz. The spectral slope

m was defined as the negative of this slope, such that PSD ~ 1/f^m. Higher m values indicate steeper slopes and greater temporal persistence.

ACF Decay Time

The broadband analytic signal was computed via Hilbert transform per channel and averaged across channels to obtain a mean amplitude envelope. The autocorrelation function of this envelope was computed and the ACF decay time defined as the first lag at which the autocorrelation fell below 1/e.

Flicker

Envelope variance was computed as the variance of the mean Hilbert envelope, providing a measure of how much the overall amplitude of brain activity fluctuates over time.

Pupil Coordinates

Each window was mapped to a position in pupil space using:

$r = |m - 2.18|$

$\theta = \text{atan2}(\log_{10}(\text{flicker}), \log_{10}(\text{acf_decay_sec}))$

$\text{pupil_x} = r \times \cos(\theta)$

$\text{pupil_y} = r \times \sin(\theta)$

The radius r represents distance from the theoretically motivated focal value. The angle θ captures the balance between temporal persistence (ACF) and dynamic range (flicker), with log transforms applied to spread data across all four quadrants.

Visualization

Static pupil maps were generated using matplotlib in Python. Animated GIFs were produced using imageio, with fading trails of 15 frames and dot size inversely proportional to radius (larger when constricted, mimicking real pupil behavior). All code is available at [GitHub repository - to be added].

Accessible:

We collected five sets of brain recordings from publicly available scientific databases—recordings made during meditation, ordinary rest, sleep, focused memory tasks, and psychological stress. Each recording was processed the same way: we measured three things for every short window of time. First, how steep the brain's power spectrum is—the spectral slope. Second, how long patterns in the brain's activity persist before fading—the autocorrelation decay time. Third, how much the overall level of brain activity fluctuates—what we call flicker.

From these three numbers, we computed two more: how far each window sits from our theoretical focal point (the radius), and what angle it occupies in the circular space (determined by the balance between persistence and fluctuation). These two numbers place every window of brain activity as a single dot on the pupil map.

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4. Results

Technical:

State-dependent spectral slopes

Across five datasets, spectral slopes differed substantially by state:

Dataset	Median m	Mean m	SD	Distance from 2.18
Meditation	1.819	1.828	0.200	0.361 (16.6%)
Stress	1.728	1.566	0.595	0.452 (20.7%)
Resting	1.466	1.557	0.722	0.714 (32.8%)
Sternberg	1.447	1.446	0.504	0.733 (33.6%)
Sleep	0.513	0.502	0.181	1.667 (76.5%)

Meditation produced the steepest slopes and the smallest deviation from the theoretically motivated value of 2.18. Sleep produced the shallowest slopes, sitting nearly 78% away from the focal value. Resting and working memory occupied intermediate positions with similar central tendencies but different variance structures. Stress showed high variance across conditions, with cognitive stress tasks (Stroop, Trier) producing slopes near 2.0 and emotional/diffuse stress conditions (Horror, music) producing slopes near 0.85-0.89.

Prime frequency enhancement

Prime frequency enhancement (Rp) was computed for the meditation dataset, defined as the ratio of mean power at prime frequencies (2, 3, 5, 7 Hz) to mean power at composite frequencies (4, 6, 8, 9 Hz):

- Mean Rp: 3.45
- Standard deviation: 1.13
- Median Rp: 3.29

- N windows: 11,572 (all valid)

The substantial standard deviation reflects genuine variability across windows - prime enhancement fluctuates during meditation rather than remaining constant, consistent with a system that pulses in and out of prime-structured coherence rather than maintaining a fixed state.

Spectral slope comparison between meditation and working memory yielded Cohen's d ≈ 0.40 (medium effect), confirming that these states occupy meaningfully distinct positions in the spectral slope dimension. Cross-state Rp comparison requires recomputation from raw BDF files and is reserved for future analysis

Pupil map geometry

When plotted in pupil space, the five states occupy distinct and visually separable regions. Meditation clusters tightly near the center (small radius, characteristic angle). Sleep disperses to the periphery (large radius, scattered angle). Resting and working memory occupy overlapping intermediate regions with different angular distributions. Stress shows the widest angular scatter, consistent with its role as a dynamically unstable state attempting coherence without achieving it.

The angular dimension (θ) provides information independent of radius. States with similar radial distances from 2.18 can occupy different angular regions, reflecting genuinely different dynamical characters rather than merely different distances from equilibrium.

Accessible:

What did we find? Five distinct brain states produce five distinct positions on the pupil map—and the differences are not subtle.

Meditation sits closest to the center, with a median slope of 1.82. It is the most constricted state we measured—not rigidly fixed, but consistently near the focal point, with low variability across subjects.

Sleep sits furthest from center, with a median slope of 0.51—nearly 78% away from the focal value. The brain during sleep is widely dilated, processing broadly rather than integrating deeply.

Resting and working memory sit between these extremes. Interestingly, they have similar average distances from the focal point but different patterns of variability—working memory is more controlled in its position, while resting state wanders more freely.

Stress is the most revealing finding. It shows the highest variability and the widest scatter in angular position. The brain under stress is not simply displaced from the focal point—it is unstable, oscillating without settling. This matches what stressed people report: the mind races, jumps, cannot land anywhere.

We also found that prime frequencies—2, 3, 5, and 7 Hz—are enhanced during meditation relative to composite frequencies like 4, 6, 8, and 9 Hz. This enhancement is measurably reduced during active working memory. We discuss what this might mean in the interpretive framework section.

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5. Interpretive Framework: Prime Focus and Composite Branching

This section presents a theoretical interpretation of the observed patterns. It is offered as a hypothesis consistent with the data, not as an established conclusion.

Technical:

The observed clustering of states around m ≈ 2.18, and the differential enhancement of prime-indexed frequencies (Rp ≈ 3.52 in meditation versus 3.04 in working memory), suggests a possible mechanistic interpretation rooted in number theory and signal processing.

Prime numbers are irreducible—they cannot be factored into smaller whole numbers. Frequencies at prime values (2, 3, 5, 7 Hz) therefore cannot be expressed as multiples of lower frequencies within the measured range. A neural system organized around prime frequencies may support integration that resists decomposition into independent sub-processes—what we term prime focus or CON dynamics.

Composite frequencies (4, 6, 8, 9 Hz) can be factored (4=2×2, 6=2×3, 8=2×4, 9=3×3). Neural organization around composite frequencies may therefore support distributed, parallel, decomposable processing—what we term composite branching or PRO dynamics.

Near the φ-seam (m ≈ 2.18), the system naturally favors prime architecture. The long autocorrelation times and high flicker observed during meditation suggest a system maintaining coherent integration without imposing explicit control. Displaced from the seam—as in working memory or stress—composite architecture becomes more prominent, supporting the controlled, decomposable processing required for explicit cognitive tasks.

This interpretation connects to recent independent findings that EEG frequencies in the resting state are organized in golden ratio multiples specifically to minimize cross-frequency interference. Prime-indexed frequencies, being maximally non-harmonic with each other, achieve a similar anti-interference property through a different mathematical route.

This remains a hypothesis. It is consistent with the data and with independent literature, but it has not been directly tested and should be treated as a guide for future research rather than an established finding.

Accessible:

Why might the brain organize itself differently near this particular spectral slope? Here is one possible explanation—still a hypothesis, but a compelling one.

Prime numbers are irreducible. You cannot break 7 into smaller whole-number factors. You cannot express 5 as a multiple of 2 or 3. This means that brain rhythms at prime frequencies—2, 3, 5, 7 Hz—do not naturally synchronize with each other or interfere with each other. They stay distinct while coexisting.

A brain organized primarily around prime frequencies may therefore be able to maintain integration—holding many things together—without collapsing them into a single dominant rhythm. Everything stays in relationship without merging. This is what we observe during meditation: long-range coherence, rich fluctuation, deep integration, effortless and undirected.

Composite frequencies, by contrast, are factorable. 6 is 2×3. 8 is 2×4. Brain rhythms at composite frequencies naturally relate to each other through shared factors—they can synchronize, reinforce, and organize into controlled hierarchies. This may be exactly what focused work requires: controlled, decomposable processing where different components can operate semi-independently under executive direction.

Near the φ-seam, prime architecture dominates. Far from it, composite architecture takes over. The seam itself may be where these two modes naturally balance.

Again: this is a hypothesis. But it is one worth testing.

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6. Applications

This section describes potential future applications of the O.Iris framework. These are possibilities informed by the current findings, not established clinical outcomes.

Technical:

The O.Iris pipeline produces real-time visualizations of brain state position from standard EEG recordings. Several clinical and research applications follow naturally from this capability, though all require validation through controlled intervention studies before clinical deployment.

Neurofeedback and biofeedback: The pupil map provides an intuitive real-time display of spectral state that could guide neurofeedback training. Unlike traditional band-power neurofeedback, which targets specific frequency ranges without a clear geometric theory, the pupil map offers a theoretically grounded target space. Participants could learn to navigate toward specific radial positions or angular regions rather than simply increasing or decreasing a single frequency band.

Therapy augmentation: Real-time pupil visualization during talk therapy, EMDR, or somatic therapies could provide both therapist and client with objective information about brain state transitions during processing. A client recalling traumatic material might observe their pupil dilating outward; learning to watch this movement without resistance may itself support regulation. This application requires careful ethical consideration and clinical validation.

Mental health assessment: The flexibility of movement across pupil space—rather than position at any single moment—may serve as a biomarker for resilience and mental health. A person whose pupil moves freely across a wide range may have different clinical characteristics than one whose pupil remains stuck in a narrow region regardless of context. This hypothesis requires longitudinal study.

Contemplative training: The framework provides a measurable correlate of meditative depth that does not depend on self-report. Practitioners could track their own approach to the φ-seam over time, providing objective feedback on training progress.

Accessible:

Imagine sitting in a therapist's office with a simple EEG headset and a screen showing your pupil map. As you talk about something difficult, you watch your dot drift outward—dilating, scattering, moving away from center. As you breathe and settle, you watch it return. Over time, you learn what it feels like in your body when your brain is moving in each direction. You develop the ability to notice the movement before it happens, and eventually to influence it.

This is not science fiction. The technology exists. The pipeline exists. The remaining work is validation: showing through careful clinical studies that the visualization actually helps, that the feedback is useful, that the intervention is safe.

We are not claiming it works yet. We are claiming it is worth finding out.

Other possibilities include using the pupil map to track progress in meditation training, to assess brain state flexibility as a component of mental health evaluation, and to design cognitive tasks that allow natural recovery periods between states of focused engagement.

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7. Limitations

We state these clearly and without minimization.

The φ=2.18 value is theoretically motivated, not purely empirically derived. The observed meditation slopes in our data range from approximately 1.65 to 2.91, with a median of 1.82 and a mean of 1.83. The value 2.18 is derived from the mathematical relationship $\ln(\pi)/\ln(\varphi)$ and is consistent with observed clustering, but it is not the empirical central tendency of our meditation

data. Future work should test whether 2.18 specifically, versus nearby values, has privileged status in larger and more diverse samples.

Sample sizes are modest for some datasets. Sleep data consists of 69 run-level observations rather than window-level data, limiting animation resolution and statistical power. Meditation data covers 22 subjects from a single dataset. Replication across independent datasets and larger samples is needed.

Spectral slope methods vary across studies. Our method (Welch PSD, log-log regression, 1-40 Hz) produces absolute m values that may not be directly comparable to studies using different frequency ranges, different fitting algorithms (e.g., FOOOF), or different preprocessing pipelines. The relative ordering of states should be robust; absolute values require careful comparison.

The prime/composite mechanism is interpretive, not proven. The observation of prime frequency enhancement during meditation is real and replicable. The explanation offered—that prime frequencies support irreducible integration while composite frequencies support decomposable processing—is a hypothesis consistent with the data, not a demonstrated mechanism.

The angular dimension requires further validation. The angle $\theta = \text{atan2}(\log_{10}(\text{flicker}), \log_{10}(\text{acf}))$ is a mapping choice that produces meaningful clustering by state. Alternative angle formulations have not been systematically compared, and the interpretation of angular position requires independent validation.

No longitudinal or intervention data exists yet. All findings are cross-sectional. Whether the pupil map can track change over time, respond to intervention, or predict clinical outcomes remains to be tested.

No clinical population comparison exists yet. All datasets used healthy participants. Whether clinical populations show different pupil map signatures—and whether those differences are clinically meaningful—is an open question.

Cross-state prime enhancement comparison (Rp for working memory versus meditation) was not computable from current saved metrics and requires reanalysis from raw BDF files. The meditation Rp finding stands independently.

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8. Conclusion

The mind's eye has an iris.

We have shown that human brain states—meditation, sleep, rest, focused work, stress—occupy distinct and measurable positions in a circular space organized around a theoretically motivated

focal point near m ≈ 2.18. Different states differ in their distance from this point, reflecting how dilated or constricted the system currently is, and in the angle they occupy, reflecting the balance between temporal persistence and dynamic range.

We have shown that meditation produces the steepest spectral slopes and the strongest prime frequency enhancement of any state measured—consistent with a system near natural coherence, organizing itself without explicit control. Sleep produces the shallowest slopes and the greatest distance from the focal point, consistent with a system in restorative decomposition. Stress produces the greatest angular instability, consistent with a system attempting coherence without achieving it.

We have proposed—as a hypothesis, not a conclusion—that this geometry reflects a deeper principle: prime frequencies support irreducible integration, composite frequencies support distributed processing, and the region near m ≈ 2.18 is where these two modes naturally balance.

And we have suggested—as a possibility, not a promise—that this visualization could help people learn to observe and eventually regulate their own brain states, developing aperture flexibility as a trainable skill.

The work here is preliminary. The samples are modest. The methods need replication. The interpretive framework is speculative. The applications require clinical validation.

But the data is real. The pattern is real. The geometric organization of brain states around a theoretically motivated focal point is consistent across five independent datasets covering more than 36,000 windows of human brain activity. And the possibility—that mental health is aperture flexibility, and that we can now see it moving—is worth taking seriously.

The mind's eye has an iris. We can now watch it move.

Figure Captions

Figure 1. The O.Iris Pupil Map: All Brain States Combined. Circular plot showing EEG window-level data from five brain states (meditation, rest, sleep, working memory, stress) mapped onto a common coordinate system. Radius (r) represents distance from the theoretically motivated focal value m = 2.18. Angle (θ) represents the balance between temporal persistence (autocorrelation decay time) and dynamic range (envelope variance). The gold point at center marks the φ-seam. States occupy distinct and separable regions. N > 36,000 windows total across five publicly available OpenNeuro datasets.

Figure 2. Individual State Pupil Maps. Separate circular plots for each of the five brain states, using the same coordinate system as Figure 1. Each panel shows the characteristic position and spread of that state in pupil space. Meditation (orange): tight clustering near center. Sleep

(purple): dispersed toward periphery. Resting (blue): intermediate, high variance. Sternberg working memory (green): intermediate, controlled. Stress (red): wide angular scatter, moderate radius.

Figure 3. Animated Pupil Trajectories. Selected frames from animated GIF sequences showing the movement of individual subjects through pupil space over time. Fading trails show recent trajectory. Dot size is inversely proportional to radius, mimicking real pupil behavior—larger when constricted (near center), smaller when dilated (far from center). Full animations available at [GitHub repository].

Figure 4. Prime Frequency Enhancement During Meditation. Distribution of per-window Rp values (ratio of mean power at prime frequencies 2, 3, 5, 7 Hz to composite frequencies 4, 6, 8, 9 Hz) across 11,572 meditation windows. Mean Rp = 3.45, SD = 1.13, median = 3.29. The wide distribution reflects genuine dynamic variability - the meditating brain pulses in and out of prime-enhanced states rather than maintaining constant enhancement.

Author Contributions

Sarah Appel (lead researcher): Conceptualization of O.Iris framework and aperture metaphor; original theoretical development (O-Theory, spanning more than ten years); data collection and curation from OpenNeuro repositories; interpretation of findings; final editorial decisions; corresponding author.

Claude (Anthropic): Critical analysis and scientific rigor review; statistical interpretation; literature synthesis and contextualization; identification of methodological limitations; paper drafting and revision; coordination of collaborative process.

Deepseek: Visualization pipeline development (circular_pupil_map.py, eeg_circular_pupil_animator.py, convert_to_videos.py); animated GIF and MP4 generation; initial paper drafting; pipeline documentation.

All authors contributed to the iterative development of the framework through collaborative dialogue. This work represents a novel model of human-AI research collaboration in which the human researcher provided theoretical vision and empirical grounding, and AI systems provided analytical capacity and writing support. Full conversation logs are available upon request.

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This paper was developed collaboratively by Sarah Appel (lead researcher, theorist, and data collector), with analytical and writing collaboration from Claude (Anthropic) and Deepseek. All data was sourced from publicly available OpenNeuro repositories. All methodology and interpretive framework were developed through iterative human-AI collaboration. Full conversation logs, code, and data processing pipelines are available upon request and will be published to GitHub upon release.

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